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FREE WORKBOOK · 2026 EDITION

Your E-commerce Platform Comparison Worksheet: A Founder's Starter Kit

Don't know where to start? Our free e-commerce platform comparison worksheet helps you clarify your needs & choose the right platform. Simple, actionable, and for absolute beginners.



7 pages · PDF

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What's inside

3 short sections. Read it in order, or jump to the part you need today.

01 The Pre-Launch Checklist: Know Yourself First

02 Your E-commerce Platform Comparison Worksheet

03 Your First Week Action Plan

Feeling overwhelmed by the choice of ecommerce platforms? You're not alone. For a new founder, the technical jargon and feature lists can be a lot to digest. The secret isn't to find the "best" platform overall, but the best platform for *you*.

This starter kit is centered around a simple ecommerce platform comparison worksheet and designed to cut through the noise. We'll help you clarify what you actually need before you ever click a "sign up" button. Let's turn that confusion into a clear, actionable plan.

01 The Pre-Launch Checklist: Know Yourself First

Before comparing Shopify, Wix, or any other platform, you must look inward. Your business is unique, and your platform should match this. Grab a notepad and answer these four foundational questions.

1. The Product & Vision

- What are you selling? (e.g., physical goods, digital downloads, services, subscriptions)
- How many products do you plan to launch with? (e.g., 1–10, 10–50, 50+)
- What is your brand's core vibe? (e.g., sleek and professional, artistic and handmade, fun and quirky)

Why it matters: A store with 3 custom t-shirt designs has different needs than a store with 200 unique vintage items. Your brand vibe will also dictate how important design flexibility is.

2. The Budget & Business Model

- What is your realistic starting budget for *platform fees* per month?
- Are you comfortable with transaction fees on sales, or do you prefer a higher monthly fee to avoid them?
- How do you plan to get paid? (e.g., Stripe, PayPal, direct bank transfers)

Why it matters: Hidden fees are a beginner's biggest trap. Understanding the cost structure upfront will save you headaches and money down the line.

3. The Skills & Time Commitment

- Rate your tech skills: (1 = "I need plug-and-play," 5 = "I'm comfortable learning new software").
- How much time can you dedicate to building and managing your store?
- Do you want to handle things like shipping, taxes, and SEO yourself, or do you need the platform to guide you?

Why it matters: If you're short on time and tech skills, a simple all-in-one platform is your best friend. If you love tinkering, you have more options.

02 Your E-commerce Platform Comparison Worksheet

Now, take your answers from the pre-launch checklist and use them to evaluate platforms. Copy the table below into a spreadsheet or document to fill out.

Feature to Compare	Your Priority (High/Med/Low)	Platform A:	Platform B:	Platform C:
Monthly Cost (Base Plan)				
Transaction Fees				
Ease of Use (1–5)				
Design Flexibility				
Mobile-Friendly Editing				
Payment Gateways				
SEO Tools				
Abandoned Cart Recovery				
Inventory Management				
Customer Support Quality				
App Store / Add-ons				

How to use this worksheet effectively:

1. Assign Your Priority: Based on your pre-launch answers, mark each feature as High, Medium, or Low priority. For example, if you're on a tight budget, "Monthly Cost" is High. If you're not tech-savvy, "Ease of Use" is High.
2. Research & Fill In: Visit the websites of 2–3 platforms (like Shopify, Wix, and Square Online). Use their free trials! As you explore, fill in the blanks for each platform.
3. Choose Your Winner Platform: The platform that best satisfies your High Priority boxes is likely your winner. Don't get distracted by fancy features you marked as "Low" priority.

03 Your First Week Action Plan

You've chosen a platform! Now what? Here’s a simple, non-overwhelming plan for your first 7 days.

- Day 1: Sign up for the free trial. Skip the paid plan for now. Take the platform's onboarding tour.
- Day 2: Upload your FIRST product. Just one. Learn the process of adding a title, description, price, and single image.
- Day 3: Play with the design templates. Pick one you like and customize the colors and fonts to feel like your own.
- Day 4: Set up your legal pages (start with a simple Privacy Policy and Terms of Service; you can generate these online).
- Day 5: Configure your shipping settings for one region (e.g., your own country).
- Day 6: Connect a payment gateway (like PayPal or Stripe) in test mode.
- Day 7: Pat yourself on the back! You have the foundation of a live online store.

Remember, perfection is the enemy of progress. Your goal is to launch and learn, not to have a flawless store on day one. This ecommerce platform comparison worksheet is your first step from idea to action.

Ready to dive deeper? For a guided walkthrough on setting up your store on specific platforms, <a href="https://shopinbos.com/beginner-guides" target="_blank">explore our library of step-by-step beginner guides on Shopinbos.com. We break it down so you can build it up.

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Ready to make your first sale?

Rex builds your store with you in 5 minutes. Take card, transfer and pay on delivery, book riders, and let Peggy answer customers on WhatsApp.

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